PROJECT: COVENANT OF THREE

PREFACE

Unlike the Game Design Document, which focuses on the world, atmosphere, and narrative foundation of the project, this document is dedicated entirely to the systems that define the player's moment-to-moment experience.

At its core, *Covenant of Three* is a tactical turn-based RPG built around the idea that every encounter should feel deliberate, calculated, and meaningful — much like a game of chess. Every action carries weight, and every mistake can shape the outcome of the battle.

The combat system is centered around a squad of three distinct specialists: a Mage, a Warrior, and a Scholar. Rather than functioning as interchangeable units, each of them represents a completely different layer of gameplay. Their abilities, resources, and roles are intentionally designed to contrast with one another, forcing the player to think not in terms of individual strength, but in terms of synergy and coordination.

This document explores the structure, logic, and philosophy behind those mechanics — defining how each system operates individually, and how they come together to create a cohesive and strategically rich experience.

Hope you enjoy reading this document.

— Denys Zaichenko

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SYSTEM OVERVIEW

Project: Covenant of Three is a tactical turn-based RPG where every battle is designed to feel like a game of chess. The player commands a squad of three specialists — a Mage, a Warrior, and a Scholar — each defined by a distinct combat role, resource profile, and unique in-battle mechanics.

The core of the system lies in decision-making. Victory is not achieved through raw power, but through understanding positioning, managing resources, and leveraging the synergy between all three characters.

DESIGN PHILOSOPHY

Combat prioritizes deliberate thinking over reflexes. Every action is intentional, and every mistake carries consequences.

Positioning is critical before the first move is made. Each character performs optimally within a specific range and orientation, requiring the player to plan ahead rather than react.

Resource management — primarily Action Points (**AP**) — introduces meaningful trade-offs. Spending AP aggressively may provide short-term advantage but leaves the squad exposed, while conserving AP enables stronger, more calculated plays in future turns.

In addition, enemy design and arena structure introduce a second layer of complexity. The same squad must adapt to different environments, such as open spaces, tight corridors, or hazard-filled arenas. Understanding the battlefield is as important as understanding the characters.

CORE DESIGN PILLARS

POSITIONING	Each character has an optimal range and role. Proper placement is the foundation of every successful encounter.
AP ECONOMY	Action Points persist between turns (up to a cap). Saving AP to execute high-impact actions is often more effective than spending inefficiently.
ARENA AWARENESS	Battlefields directly influence gameplay. Arena size, layout, obstacles, and environmental hazards determine which abilities are viable and safe to use.
ADAPTABILITY	Different enemy types require different approaches. The Scholar identifies weaknesses, the Mage exploits them, and the Warrior applies pressure. Ignoring this interplay leads to failure.
UNIQUE MECHANICS	Each character has a personal sub-system — the Mage's Amulet, the Warrior's weapon stance, the Scholar's construct network — that adds depth beyond basic attack-and-move.

GAMEPLAY LOOP

Each encounter follows a structured loop designed to create tension and strategic pacing:

1. **DEPLOYMENT**
   The player positions all three characters within a designated starting zone before the battle begins.
2. **TURN ORDER**
   Units act in alternating turns. Each unit acts once per round. The player controls all three characters sequentially.
3. **ACTION PHASE**
   Characters spend Action Points (AP) on movement, abilities, attacks, or defensive actions. Unused AP carries over to the next turn, up to the maximum limit.

4. **ENEMY RESPONSE**
   Enemies take their turns based on defined AI behaviors and AP constraints that mirror the player’s system.
5. **ROUND END**
   All units regenerate AP. Environmental effects (such as fire, fog, or flooding) update and persist.
6. **VICTORY / DEFEAT**
   The battle ends when all enemies are eliminated, or when all three squad members are incapacitated simultaneously.

CHARACTERS & COMBAT ROLES

The squad consists of three characters with distinct combat identities. Their strengths are designed to complement one another — the Mage controls the field from afar, the Warrior applies pressure at close range, and the Scholar supports and disrupts from a flexible position.

THE MAGE

The Mage is the squad's primary damage dealer and battlefield controller. Her spells can reshape entire zones — freezing rivers, igniting corridors, obscuring visibility — but their power comes with a critical caveat: area-of-effect abilities do not discriminate between friend and foe. Positioning the Mage correctly before casting is non-negotiable.

- **ROLE:** Ranged spellcaster / Squad buffe.
- **OPTIMAL RANGE:** Long distance (8–15+ cells).
- **AP PROFILE:** Highest base AP in squad.

THE AMULET SYSTEM

The Amulet is the Mage's defining mechanic. It contains 3 slots, each capable of holding one elemental stone. Before or during combat, the player loads stones into the

slots; the combination of stones determines which spell is cast when the Mage uses her action. Spells can be formed from a single stone (basic elemental attack), a pair (combined element with new properties), or all three stones (powerful compound spell). The same stone type can appear in multiple slots to amplify its effect.

THE ELEMENTAL STONES

Four elemental stone types are currently defined. Each has a base single-stone spell and participates in combination effects with other elements:

STONE	SINGLE-STONE EFFECT	COMBINATION EXAMPLE
Fire	Fireball — moderate AoE damage	Fire+Fire+Fire = Mega Fireball (large AoE, extended burn zone) Fire+Ice = Steam Cloud (50% hit-chance penalty for all units inside)
Ice	Ice Spear - Hits one target, applies a freezing effect.	Ice+Water = Blizzard (AoE slow + freeze chance) Ice+Wind = Hail Storm (AoE + knockback)
Lightning	Chain Bolt - Jumps between adjacent enemies	Lightning+Water = Electro Flood (shocks all units on water tiles) Lightning+Wind = Thunder Strike (high single-target, stun chance)
Wind	Gust — pushes target 2 cells	Wind+Wind+Wind = Cyclone (large AoE push, clears burning/steam tiles) Wind+Fire = Firestorm (spreads burn zone by 3 cells per turn)

Note: combination spell lists above are illustrative examples to demonstrate system logic. Full spell tables are to be defined during production.

ARENA SIZE & SPELL SAFETY

AoE spells project outward from the target cell in a radius defined by the spell. On a 10×10 arena, a large-radius spell will almost certainly overlap ally positions. The player must weigh spell power against arena dimensions and ally placement before every cast. This risk is intentional — it makes large arenas feel like opportunities and small arenas feel like threats.

THE WARRIOR

The Warrior is the squad's melee specialist. He operates exclusively at close range and must be manoeuvred into position before engaging. Once adjacent to enemies, he is the most physically powerful character in the squad — capable of dealing high single-target damage or hitting multiple foes with area attacks unlocked through the skill tree.

- **ROLE:** Melee frontliner / Damage dealer.
- **OPTIMAL RANGE:** Adjacent cells (1–3).
- **AP PROFILE:** Mid base AP; high per-action impact.

WEAPON CONFIGURATION SYSTEM

The Warrior does not lock into a predefined stance before combat. Instead, his combat role is defined by equipment choices made through a flexible inventory system.

The Warrior has two weapon slots, allowing the player to configure his playstyle based on the selected combination:

- **ONE-HANDED WEAPON + SHIELD**
  Provides balanced damage output and increased survivability. The shield grants defensive bonuses, making this configuration effective for holding positions and absorbing incoming damage.

- **TWO-HANDED WEAPON (Greatsword, Warhammer, etc.)**

Significantly increases damage output at the cost of reduced defense. Without a shield, the Warrior becomes more vulnerable, but excels at dealing high damage, especially against grouped enemies.

This system allows the player to define the Warrior’s role dynamically, shifting between a defensive frontline unit and an aggressive damage dealer, depending on the chosen equipment.

Rather than forcing a fixed stance, the design encourages adaptation through loadout decisions, reinforcing the game's core philosophy of strategic planning and player-driven playstyle.

ATTACK TYPES

The Warrior's attack repertoire expands through the skill tree. Base attacks are available from the start; special techniques are unlocked progressively:

ATTACK TYPE	TARGET PATTERN	AP COST	UNLOCK
Basic Strike	Single adjacent cell	2	Default
Defensive Stance	Self	1	Default
Spin Slash	All adjacent cells (360°)	4	Skill tree
Charge Strike	Line (3 cells forward)	3	Skill tree
Overhead Smash	Target + 1 cell behind	4	Skill tree (Two-Handed only)
Shield Bash	Single adjacent, applies Stun	3	Skill tree (One-Handed only)
Pinpoint Strike	Single — ignores partial cover	3	Skill tree

Note: The attack examples provided are intended to illustrate system design and progression logic. Final abilities and skill tree unlocks will be defined during production.

THE SCHOLAR

The Scholar is the squad's most mechanically complex character. He can fight directly with a pistol, or delegate offensive power to a network of deployed constructs while reserving his own AP for repairs, upgrades, and field engineering. His effectiveness scales with how well the player manages the tension between personal action and construct maintenance.

- **ROLE:** Engineer / Support / Flex.
- **OPTIMAL RANGE:** Flexible (near or far).
- **AP PROFILE:** Mid base AP; distributed between self and constructs.

CONSTRUCTION SLOTS & SLOT TYPES

The Scholar has a fixed number of deployment slots shared between constructs and active skills. Each slot can hold either a construct (deployed on the field) or a skill (personal ability). The number of slots increases via the skill tree.

- Constructs occupy both a slot in the Scholar's loadout and a physical cell on the grid when deployed.
- Skills occupy a slot but have no physical presence — they are activated directly by the Scholar.
- Mixing construct and skill slots is encouraged; the ratio is determined by the player's build.

CONSTUCTION TYPES

Constructs are mechanical devices placed on the battlefield. They act autonomously or under direct Scholar control, depending on the active mode (see below).

CONSTRUCT	TYPE	FUNCTION
Barrier Shield	Defensive	Provides full cover to adjacent allies; can be upgraded for higher durability
Auto-Turret	Ranged offensive	Fires at nearest enemy each round; damage scales with upgrade level

Rocket Launcher	Heavy ranged	High AoE damage; long reload; expensive to deploy and repair
Bridge / Platform	Utility	Creates traversable surface over impassable tiles (rivers, gaps)
Trap Module	Control	Triggers on enemy entry — slows, stuns, or damages
Scanner Array*	Support (skill)	Reveals enemy weaknesses or ability patterns

Note: The construct types and examples described in this section are intended to illustrate the Scholar's system design and progression logic. Final constructs, parameters, and skill tree unlocks will be defined during production and balancing.

* Scanner Array is a skill-type slot entry, not a physical construct. It is listed here to illustrate the slot-sharing mechanic.

SCHOLAR ACTION MODES

On each turn, the Scholar selects one of two operational modes. This decision defines how both the Scholar and his constructs behave during that round. Rather than acting as a fixed support unit, the Scholar functions as a hybrid control system between direct participation and full construct coordination:

- **DIRECT CONTROL MODE**
  The Scholar acts independently using his Action Points (AP), performing standard actions such as attacking, moving, repairing, or upgrading constructs. During this mode, constructs operate autonomously, engaging enemies based on predefined AI behavior (e.g., auto-turrets targeting the nearest enemy, melee constructs engaging nearby threats).

- **CONSTRUCT COMMAND MODE**
  The Scholar sacrifices his personal actions for full battlefield control. In this mode, he issues direct commands to all active constructs, including movement orders, ability activation, and chained interactions between units. Constructs do not act independently during this mode and instead execute only the Scholar's explicit instructions, allowing for coordinated and high-precision tactical plays.

PISTOL ATTACK

The Scholar's personal ranged weapon is a pistol. Unlike most ranged weapons, the pistol scales inversely with distance: maximum damage is dealt at point-blank range (1–2 cells), and damage decreases as distance increases. This encourages the Scholar to occasionally move into the front line rather than always staying at the back.

CONSTRUCT UPGRADE & REPAIR COSTS

Both upgrading and repairing constructs cost AP and are performed in Direct Control mode as the Scholar's action for that turn.

ACTION	AP COST	EFFECT
Repair (minor)	2	Restores 30% of construct HP
Repair (full)	4	Restores construct to full HP
Upgrade (Tier 2)	3	Improves damage or durability
Upgrade (Tier 3)	5	Adds secondary function or AoE

Note: The mode descriptions and behaviors provided in this table are intended as illustrative examples of the Scholar's system design. Final values, interactions, and implementations will be defined during production and balancing.

CHARACTER REVIVAL

If a squad member is reduced to 0 HP, they are incapacitated — they fall on their current cell and cannot act. They are not permanently eliminated. Any other active squad member may use AP to revive them, restoring them to a partial HP value (exact percentage TBD). If all three members are simultaneously incapacitated, the battle is lost.

Revival is a meaningful decision: spending AP to bring back a fallen ally means sacrificing significant offensive or repositioning capacity that turn. In many situations, a well-timed revival is worth the cost; in others, spending that AP to finish the fight faster is the correct call.

BATTLE FIELD

Combat takes place on a square grid of variable dimensions. The grid is the tactical canvas: its size, tile composition, and environmental features define the strategic possibilities available in each encounter.

GRID & ARENA SIZES

Arena dimensions scale with encounter type. Smaller arenas create claustrophobic, high-stakes confrontations where area-effect abilities are dangerous for both sides. Larger arenas give the squad room to manoeuvre and allow the Mage to deploy wide-range spells without risking allies.

ARENA TYPE	GRID SIZE	TYPICAL USE	NOTES
Confined	10 × 10	Dungeon rooms, traps	AoE spells extremely risky
Standard	20 × 20	Most combat encounters	Balanced positioning options
Open	35 × 35	Outdoor fights, ambushes	Ranged units advantaged
Grand	50 × 50	Boss arenas, sieges	Large AoE spells fully safe

TILE TYPES

Each cell on the battlefield grid is defined by a specific tile type, which can influence movement, positioning, and combat outcomes. Rather than serving as a purely visual element, terrain plays an active role in shaping player decisions and tactical planning.

Certain tiles modify how characters interact with the environment. For example, water surfaces amplify lightning-based effects, while burning tiles deal continuous damage to units standing on them. Ice introduces risk by potentially disrupting movement, and elevated terrain provides advantages for ranged attacks.

Other tile types act as obstacles or strategic modifiers. Rubble offers partial cover but may interfere with certain actions, such as construction. Deep water blocks standard movement entirely, requiring alternative solutions. These environmental conditions encourage the player to consider terrain not only when navigating the battlefield, but also when choosing abilities, positioning units, and planning overall strategy.

ACTION POINTS SYSTEM

Action Points (AP) are the universal currency of combat. Every action — movement, attack, ability, stance change, construct interaction — costs AP. The system is designed so that each decision carries a real trade-off, encouraging planning across multiple turns rather than spending everything available each round.

CORE RULES

The Action Point (AP) system is governed by a set of core rules that define how resources are generated, stored, and utilized during combat. Each character operates within a fixed AP cap, which limits the maximum amount of points that can be accumulated regardless of how efficiently they are conserved.

At the start of each turn, characters regenerate a base amount of AP. This regeneration rate can be influenced by skills, equipment, or other gameplay systems, allowing for variation in resource flow depending on the chosen build.

Unused AP is not lost at the end of a turn. Instead, it carries over and contributes to the next turn's total, up to the maximum cap. This mechanic forms the foundation of strategic resource banking, enabling players to save points for more impactful actions in future turns.

Additionally, characters begin each encounter with different base AP values, reflecting their intended roles. The Mage starts with a higher initial AP pool to support complex spell combinations and repositioning, while the Warrior and Scholar begin with lower values, relying on their unique mechanics to remain effective.

AP COST EXAMPLE

The following costs are baseline values. Skills, equipment, and status effects may alter them.

ACTION	AP COST	NOTES
Move 1 cell	1	Difficult tiles cost 2–3

Basic attack (melee)	2	Warrior base
Basic attack (ranged / pistol)	2	Scholar base
Defensive stance	1	Reduces incoming damage this turn
Light spell (single stone)	2-3	Mage — varies by element
Combo spell (2–3 stones)	4-6	Mage — higher cost, higher effect
Construct deployment (Scholar)	3-4	Depends on construct type
Construct repair / upgrade	2-4	Depends on construct and action
Special ability / technique	3-5	Unlocked via skill tree
Revive fallen ally	5	Restores ally with partial HP

ENEMY AP

Enemies operate under the same AP system as the player's squad. Standard enemies share the same base values and regen rate. Boss enemies may have higher AP caps, different regen rates, or special rules that override standard behaviour — these are defined on a per-boss basis.

CARRY-OVER EXAMPLE

The following example demonstrates how AP accumulates across turns for the Warrior (base AP: 6, regen: +2/turn, cap: 10)

TURN	AP START	ACTION TAKEN	AP SPENT	AP REMAINING	AP NEXT TURN
1	6	Basic attack	2	4	4 + 2 = 6
2	6	Defensive stance	1	5	5 + 2 = 7
3	7	Heavy special attack	5	2	2 + 2 = 4
4	4	Move + Basic attack	3	1	1 + 2 = 3

This example shows how saving AP in Turn 2 enables a powerful Turn 3 attack, then the player recovers into Turn 4 with a moderate budget. Strategic banking creates natural rhythm and meaningful decisions without arbitrary limits.

SKILL TREE & PROGRESSION

EXPERIENCE & SKILL POINTS

The player earns experience points (XP) at the end of each successfully completed battle. XP accumulates toward character levels; each new level grants one Skill Point (SP). The player freely assigns each SP to any of the three skill trees — there is no per-character level, only a shared pool of points distributed according to the player's priorities. This design encourages deliberate build choices: investing heavily in one character makes them a specialist, while spreading points creates a more balanced squad. Neither approach is universally optimal — the correct distribution depends on the encounter ahead.

SKILL TREE OVERVIEW

Each character has an independent skill tree. The trees are divided into thematic branches. Some nodes at the outer edges of different trees share connection points — inter-class nodes — that require investment in both connected trees to unlock. These shared nodes represent squad-level synergies. Specific inter-class node content is to be defined during production (TBD).

MAGE SKILL TREE – KEY BRANCHES

- Arcane Slots — Unlocks additional Amulet configuration presets, allowing the Mage to pre-set multiple stone loadouts and switch between them during battle.
- Elemental Mastery — Upgrades specific element types — e.g., Fire Mastery increases burn damage and extends burn tile duration; Ice Mastery reduces the AP cost of ice spells.
- Mana Efficiency — Reduces AP cost of spell combos; also increases the Mage's base AP cap.
- Supportive Magic — Unlocks buff and debuff spells: ally damage boosts, enemy movement penalties, and area denial tools.
- Overcharge — Allows the Mage to overclock a spell by spending extra AP for amplified effects — larger radius, doubled damage, or extended duration.

WARRIOR SKILL TREE – KEY BRANCHES

- Combat Techniques — Unlocks advanced attack patterns: Spin Slash, Charge Strike, Overhead Smash, Shield Bash, and Pinpoint Strike.
- Physical Conditioning — Increases base HP, reduces AP cost of movement, and unlocks passive regeneration of a small amount of HP per round.
- Heavy Armour — Allows equipping heavy armour sets, significantly increasing defence at the cost of reduced movement range per AP.
- Weapon Specialisation — Deepens either the Shield Bearer or Two-Handed branch — each grants passive bonuses unique to that stance.
- Battle Fury — Passive: each consecutive hit on the same turn increases the Warrior's damage by a stacking percentage.

SCHOLAR SKILL TREE – KEY BRANCHES

- Construct Slots — Unlocks additional deployment slots, allowing more constructs and skills to be equipped simultaneously.
- Engineering Mastery — Reduces AP cost of construct repair and upgrade actions; constructs gain increased base HP and durability.
- Weapons Research — Unlocks new construct types and improves existing ones — adds Tier 3 upgrade options and secondary functions.
- Precision Targeting — Improves pistol damage at all ranges; unlocks a focused shot ability that deals high single-target damage at a higher AP cost.
- Scanner Network — Unlocks Scanner Array and enhances it — extended duration, additional revealed information (ability cooldowns, resistances).

SKILL RESET

Whether players can reset and reallocate Skill Points is to be determined during production. Design consideration: a reset system increases build experimentation and reduces the penalty for early decisions made without full knowledge of the game. A limited reset (e.g., once per act, or via a rare consumable) is recommended as a baseline design direction.

SYSTEM INTERACTIONS & SYNERGIES

CORE SYSTEM INTERACTIONS

Combat in *Covenant of Three* is built around synergy between the three characters, where the effectiveness of one action is often amplified by the setup created by another. Rather than acting independently, the Mage, Warrior, and Scholar are designed to function as an interconnected system, rewarding coordinated play.

The Scholar typically initiates interactions by gathering information or altering the battlefield. For example, scanning enemies to reveal elemental weaknesses enables the Mage to deal increased damage with the appropriate spells. Similarly, deploying constructs such as bridges or turrets reshapes the battlefield, allowing the Warrior to engage otherwise unreachable targets or establish advantageous positions.

The Mage often acts as both a setup and payoff unit. By applying status effects or modifying terrain — such as freezing enemies or creating vision-obscuring steam clouds — the Mage creates opportunities for the Warrior to deliver stronger or safer attacks. These effects can increase damage output or reduce the risk of enemy retaliation.

The Warrior serves as the primary executor, capitalizing on openings created by the other two characters. By controlling enemy positioning, drawing attention, or holding key areas, he enables both the Scholar's constructs and the Mage's abilities to operate more effectively. In certain scenarios, the combination of a defensive Warrior and enhanced constructs can create controlled “kill zones” that dominate specific areas of the battlefield.

Together, these interactions form a layered system where setup, execution, and payoff are distributed across all three roles. Mastery of the game depends on the player's ability to recognize and combine these synergies in response to both enemy behavior and environmental conditions.

DESIGN INTENT

Synergies are opt-in rewards, not mandatory mechanics. A player who ignores them can still complete encounters, but a player who identifies and executes multi-character combos will find battles significantly more efficient and rewarding. This creates a natural skill ceiling that separates casual play from mastery without locking content behind it.

Inter-class skill tree nodes (TBD) will formalise some of these synergies as explicit mechanical bonuses, rewarding players who invest in cross-character relationships rather than treating each character as an isolated build.